Case Study: The "QR Code" UPI Scam

The Crime: UPI Payment Fraud - UPI (Unified Payments Interface) fraud is a type of cybercrime where attackers trick victims into authorizing unauthorized fund transfers from their bank accounts using mobile payment apps. Unlike hacking, this relies on **social engineering**—manipulating the victim into voluntarily giving up control.

How it Happens (Step-by-Step)

1. **The Bait:** The scammer poses as a buyer on a platform like OLX or Facebook Marketplace. They contact a seller (the victim) and agree to buy an item immediately without negotiation.
2. **The Hook:** The scammer claims they are sending a "payment link" or a **QR Code** to the victim to "receive" the money.
3. **The Deception:** The scammer sends a QR code via WhatsApp, telling the victim, "Scan this to receive your payment."
4. **The Theft:** In reality, scanning a QR code is only for **sending** money, never receiving it. When the victim scans the code and enters their **UPI PIN**, they are actually authorizing a debit from their own account. The money is instantly transferred to the scammer's account.

The Target- Common targets include small-scale online sellers, senior citizens unfamiliar with digital payment nuances, and students looking for quick deals or part-time jobs online.

The Consequences-The primary consequence is immediate **financial loss**, which is often difficult to reverse because the victim technically "authorized" the transaction with their PIN. Secondary consequences include emotional distress and a loss of trust in digital banking systems.

Real-World Incident: In a widely reported case by *The Hindu* (2023), a Bengaluru resident lost ₹1.5 lakh after scanning a QR code sent by a fake buyer on a secondary marketplace. The scammer vanished as soon as the PIN was entered.